situation following the collapse of Denikin had deteriorated to the extent that Norperforce was now extremely vulnerable. As such, on 13 May it recommended moving the troops from Tabriz and Enzeli to Kazvin.[43] However, at a meeting of the Eastern Committee a few days later, to which neither Churchill nor Wilson were invited or even had knowledge of, the decision was taken against evacuating Enzeli. 'In consequence of this, our force has first been rounded up and then allowed to retire in circumstances of great humiliation to the British arms', Churchill fumed at Curzon.[44]

Recrimination was followed by counter-recrimination. Wilson could not resist his own taunt at Curzon, asking the foreign secretary if he might in future 'trust, a little, in the advice of the responsible military advisers'.[45] Curzon, however, was not prepared to take the blame for the situation and acidly replied to Wilson that it was the War Office that had consistently given the wrong information regarding Enzeli:

Who was it who wrote the telegram of Feb. 13 telling the Enzeli force to hold on?...not the FO but the WO...Who was it who came repeatedly to E[astern Committee] Conferences and told us that the WO view was that the Bolshevik policy in Persia was not military but propaganda? Not I but General Radcliffe. Therefore do not my dear Field Marshal accuse me of being indifferent to military advice. I have trusted it too implicitly![46]

In the days, weeks and months that followed Enzeli, debate over Persia would become intense. Despite the humiliation of what had occurred, there were still those within the British government, such as Curzon and Milner, who believed that complete withdrawal from Persia 'would weaken our whole position in the East'.[47] The War Office, on the other hand, vehemently pressed for the evacuation not only of the force at Enzeli, but all the various troops stationed in north Persia and in Batum, to fall back to Mesopotamia over the next few weeks in order to avoid any further embarrassment.[48] As Churchill pointed out in a letter to Curzon on 20 May, 'If we are not able to resist the Bolsheviks in these areas, it is much better